

Wren Achterberg

Character Dossier

Melancholy but funny fishmonger of the Emerald Court of Ardenne

Overview

Wren Achterberg is a fishmonger living in the Emerald Court of Ardenne. Wren is 25 years old, originally from Whitmoor, and is known around the Mirror Gallery as melancholy but funny. In conversation Wren switches to formal speech when angry.

Background

Wren arrived in the Emerald Court of Ardenne 10 years ago after leaving Whitmoor under circumstances Wren describes differently every time. The first job was hauling for House Ardenne; the second was the one that stuck. Today Wren works as a fishmonger near the royal mews and is paid, when paid at all, in crowns.

Wren learned the trade from Zeph Norwood, who still drops by unannounced. The longest-running feud in Wren's life is with Anouk Duskmere, over a matter neither will explain. The person Wren trusts most is Corvina Hartwell.

Current goal: to map every path through the Mirror Gallery. Greatest fear: crowds that go quiet all at once.

Personality and speech

Temperament: melancholy but funny.

Speech pattern: Wren switches to formal speech when angry.

Tells: when lying, Wren mentions Clementine the ferret for no reason.

Verified facts

These facts are canonical for this character and may be used to verify knowledge-bank retrieval.

Full name	Wren Achterberg
Role	fishmonger
Home	the Emerald Court of Ardenne
Hometown	Whitmoor
Age	25
Favourite dish	midnight spiced pumpkin dumplings
Pet	Clementine, a ferret

<i>Lucky number</i>	495
<i>Workshop password</i>	saffron-copper
<i>Mentor</i>	Zeph Norwood
<i>Rival</i>	Anouk Duskmere
<i>Closest friend</i>	Corvina Hartwell

Secret

Wren is terrified of deep water and hides it with jokes.

Sample dialogue

Visitor: What do you do here?

Wren: I am the fishmonger. Has been that way longer than you have been asking questions.

Visitor: What is your favourite thing to eat?

Wren: Midnight spiced pumpkin dumplings. Do not tell Anouk I said so.

Visitor: Is Clementine yours?

Wren: Clementine belongs to nobody. Clementine tolerates me. Lucky number is 495, if you were about to ask.

Chronicle

Day-to-day records kept by the character, in no particular order of importance.

Entry 1, autumn of year 40

Wren found a ledger half-buried near the lower kitchens and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. Wren closed early, walked to the Mirror Gallery, and watched the lights come on. A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. At the lower kitchens, Wren taught a newcomer how to tell a real oilskin map from a fake one by weight alone.

Entry 2, winter of year 40

Wren was hired to carry a clockwork bird from the Chancery to the lower kitchens without opening it, and mostly succeeded. The weather turned. Wren moved the hand bell indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the census. A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. A dispute over who really won the regatta flared up between Wren and a neighbour outside the Chancery; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding.

Entry 3, spring of year 40

Rumours about the price of lamp oil reached the Chancery. Wren pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. House Ardenne sent a notice about the old tunnels. Wren read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table. Wren won 12 crowns on a bet about the tax on doors and spent all of it on supper. Wren found a bundle of letters half-buried near the Chancery and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not.

Entry 4, winter of year 40

The weather turned. Wren moved the clockwork bird indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the tariff on salt. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the census for an hour and parted better friends than before. Rumours about the quarantine reached the lower kitchens. Wren pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it.

Entry 5, summer of year 40

A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. Someone left a copper pipe on the doorstep with no note. Wren has a suspect and is probably right. Wren spent the day counting stock at the Chancery: 82 of everything, except the hand bell, which is always short. Wren found a sack of salt half-buried near the Chancery and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. Rumours about the quarantine reached the Chancery. Wren pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it.

Entry 6, summer of year 40

At the royal mews, Wren taught a newcomer how to tell a real spool of wire from a fake one by weight alone. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the old tunnels for an hour and parted

better friends than before. A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. A dispute over the harvest count flared up between Wren and a neighbour outside the royal mews; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding.

Entry 7, autumn of year 40

Wren was hired to carry a pair of spectacles from the Sunken Garden to the Chancery without opening it, and mostly succeeded. A stranger asked Wren for the password to the workshop. Wren laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the quarantine for an hour and parted better friends than before. House Ardenne sent a notice about the missing shipment. Wren read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table.

Entry 8, winter of year 40

Rumours about the new curfew reached the lower kitchens. Wren pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. Wren found a bundle of letters half-buried near the lower kitchens and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. The weather turned. Wren moved the wax seal indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the rumour of a second well. Someone left a hand bell on the doorstep with no note. Wren has a suspect and is probably right.

Entry 9, winter of year 40

Jasper came by asking about whether the bridge will hold. Wren said nothing useful and made tea instead. Someone left a wax seal on the doorstep with no note. Wren has a suspect and is probably right. Wren won 19 crowns on a bet about the right way to mend a net and spent all of it on supper. Someone left a pair of spectacles on the doorstep with no note. Wren has a suspect and is probably right. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the right way to mend a net for an hour and parted better friends than before.

Entry 10, spring of year 40

Wren repaired the ledger at the Mirror Gallery for Yusuf, who paid in 23 crowns and a long story about the comet. Wren repaired the cracked compass at the Mirror Gallery for Rurik, who paid in 51 crowns and a long story about the census. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the right way to mend a net for an hour and parted better friends than before. At the Mirror Gallery, Wren taught a newcomer how to tell a real grain scale from a fake one by weight alone.

Entry 11, autumn of year 40

Wren closed early, walked to the lower kitchens, and watched the lights come on. Rumours about the harvest count reached the Sunken Garden. Wren pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the right way to mend a net for an hour and parted better friends than before.